accurate," he says. A very high-end concierge might still find a ticket no one else can, he concedes, but for routine requests, he sees little reason to pay a premium. "Whatever is publicly available, AI will access."

THE HUMAN PREMIUM

"I would say that AI understands what you ask for; a great concierge understands what you actually mean," says Mishti Bose, CEO of Quintessentially India. "AI can recommend restaurants, build an itinerary or suggest ideas for a birthday. But there are many situations where the value lies in knowing why a member is asking for something and what would make it meaningful to them."

She explains with an example. A client wanted to surprise her son on his birthday by transforming an entire room into a Lego city. More than 35 Lego sets had to be sourced from different locations, delivered within days, and assembled into a miniature world.

An AI tool could have suggested a Lego city for the birthday, listed the sets to buy, even placed the order. But it couldn't have created the immersive experience the mother wanted for her son. That, Bose thinks, is the distinction. "Information is increasingly democratised by technology. Relationships aren't," she says.



"A few years ago, a good lifestyle manager was someone with a great memory. Now the system does the remembering. Technology lets that one person look after more families, and do it well, without dropping anything"

NITIN MOHAN SRIVASTAVA
FOUNDER AND CEO, PINCH

The concierge business has changed immensely over the years. The requests themselves have changed. "In 1998 a request was about access and legwork: a passport renewed, a bill paid, a table found, a gift delivered," says Sikand. "There was no internet. The concierge was the internet."

When Quintessentially started in India, Bose says, members mostly wanted access: a difficult restaurant reservation, a particular hotel, tickets to an event, help in planning a holiday. Today a request may look simple and carry a deeper purpose. "A parent may not simply be looking for a chess coach for their child. They may be looking for an experience that could genuinely inspire that child," says Bose. "A member wanted his eight-year-old son to learn from Viswanathan Anand. We were able to arrange private one-to-one coaching."

Bose calls AI "a very powerful enabler" that helps her teams research faster and streamline routine work, leaving lifestyle managers "more time to focus on the member". What it cannot supply, Sikand says, is what a concierge learns on the job. "A great concierge has spent years in the real world. They know which hotel manager picks up at midnight, which chef will open the kitchen for a birthday, which visa officer needs which document, and how to rescue an evening when everything has gone wrong," says Sikand. "That knowledge was earned through rigorous, lived experience, request by request and city by city, across 150+ countries and over decades." None of that, she says, is in any dataset.

Bhangay has built Indulge on the same premise. He gives the analogy of the watch. A smartwatch has become ubiquitous these days. It does a lot more, and yet "eight out of 10 HNIs still wear a Patek Philippe or a Rolex, and not an Apple Watch".

Human personal assistance may account for only a small share of a market for AI assistants that could run into trillions of dollars. But even that sliver could represent a substantial business. The opportunity lies not in competing with AI at scale, but in preserving the value of human assistance in an increasingly automated world. BT